



INTERNATIONAL UNIVERSITY OF
VIETNAM NATIONAL UNIVERSITIES-HCM CITY - VIETNAM
SCHOOL OF BIOMEDICAL ENGINEERING
"High Quality – Sustainability – Usefulness"



LETTER OF SUPPORT

To: Sydney Vietnam Institute Seed Grant

RE: **Huong Thi-Thanh HA**

June 25th, 2025

To Whom It May Concern,

I am Nguyen Thi Hiep, Dean of School of Biomedical Engineering at the International University (IU). I am writing this letter to strongly support Dr Huong Ha, who is applying for Sydney Vietnam Institute Seed Grant. Huong is a devoted faculty member in our School and a member of the International University, Vietnam National Universities in Ho Chi Minh City (VNU-HCM).

For your information, VNU-HCM is one of the two leading public university networks in Vietnam. It was established in 1995 by grouping the elite public universities in the city. IU was established in 2003 as a platform to promote the reform of higher education in Vietnam. It is the first public university that teaches all courses in English. It has extensive collaborations with many universities in Australia, New Zealand, Thailand, Malaysia, Singapore, the United Kingdom and the United States of America. At IU, there are more than 10.000 students and 500 faculty members. The School of Biomedical Engineering Department (BME) at IU was established in 2009 as a department of IU before it became a school in 2019. It is the first in the country that offers the accredited degree of Engineer in BME (an equivalent of the BS BME in the U.S.) and the accredited Master's and Ph.D. degrees in BME. In 2015, ASEAN University Network Quality Assurance (AUN-QA) ranked our program first in Vietnam and 2nd in ASEAN among all programs in science, engineering, business and humanity assessed at that point in time. In Sep, 2019, our program obtained the accreditation from ABET, an American-based educational quality assessment organization and in 2024, our master training program obtained the accreditation from ASIIN.

When Huong returned to Vietnam for career establishment, I was really impressed by how passionate she was about her goal of dedication to the neuroscience community in Vietnam. As the Dean of the School of Biomedical Engineering at the time, I fully supported her application to our School. Working with her for many years gave me a firsthand perspective on her remarkable abilities. Starting as a freshly graduated PhD, she formulated research goals and executed projects with innovative ideas aimed at addressing specific challenges faced by the Vietnamese population. During her tenure at BME, she spearheaded diverse research projects spanning neuroscience. These included developing a web-based platform for automated Alzheimer's disease diagnosis, exploring Brain-Computer Interface systems using motor imagery for stroke rehabilitation,



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collaborating on a point-of-care device for quantifying cortisol (a stress marker) and investigating its effects on emotional responses. Huong's research extended beyond the lab, fostering collaborations between universities, companies, and hospitals in and outside Vietnam. She actively built connections with neurologists and pathologists across various departments at the University of Medicine and Pharmacy in Ho Chi Minh City, the 175 Military Hospital, Nguyen Tri Phuong Hospital and the April 30th Hospital. Leveraging her reputation, Huong secured a long-term collaboration with EMOTIV Inc., gaining support for her research on EEG-based diagnosis of stress and Alzheimer's disease.

In summary, Huong's exceptional academic record, including her selection as a Stanford Neuroscience graduate student and numerous prestigious awards, is a testament to her remarkable abilities. Her expertise in neuroscience, particularly in utilizing artificial intelligence and other cutting-edge technologies to address Alzheimer's disease in low-middle-income countries, perfectly aligns with the collaborative research focused on aiding patients in Vietnamese areas. I have unwavering confidence in Huong's leadership and wholeheartedly support her in leading this project to success. Please do not hesitate to contact me if you need any further information.

With best regards,

Thi-Hiep NGUYEN, PhD.

Associate Professor,

Dean,

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